Fate's Edge: Design & Review Compendium

Design Team

Contents

Introduction

This document compiles three essential resources for designers and reviewers evaluating *Fate's Edge*:

1. **Reviewer's Guide** – A framework for assessing the game's narrative-first design, progressive complexity, and storytelling partnership model.
2. **Mechanics Breakdown** – A detailed analysis of the core resolution engine, resource economy, and tactical levers.
3. **Tiered Heuristics** – Optimal play strategies for Tiers I–IV, grounded in probability and resource scarcity.

All content is presented as raw LaTeX for integration into production documents. No editorial commentary is included; the material is forward-facing for fellow designers and reviewers.

Part I

Reviewer's Guide: Understanding Fate's Edge

This section will be removed in production.

1 Reframing the Evaluation

Fate's Edge is not a traditional tabletop RPG to be evaluated by comprehensive rule mastery. Instead, it is a **narrative partnership** designed to evolve with your table's storytelling sophistication. Approach this review through the lens of **progressive storytelling enhancement** rather than static mechanical complexity.

2 Key Evaluation Framework

2.1 Start Simple, Discover Naturally

- **Session 1**: Core mechanic + 1–2 regional generators = complete playable experience
- **Session 5**: Comfortable integration of multiple subsystems
- **Session 20**: Intuitive mastery where mechanics become invisible

2.2 The Partnership Model

Rather than "learning a game," players develop a "storytelling partnership" where:

- Rules serve narrative consequences, not simulation accuracy
- Complexity emerges from interaction, not individual component sophistication
- Prep burden shifts from authoring content to facilitating discovery

3 Common Misunderstandings to Address

3.1 Content Volume vs. Discovery Process

Misconception: "Too much content to master"
Reality: Content is designed for gradual discovery through play

> *Reviewer Guidance:* "Imagine a library where you only need to know about the books relevant to today's story. The rest exist to be discovered when narrative ambition demands them."

3.2 Prep-Light vs. Prep-Free

Misconception: "No prep means unstructured play"
Reality: Prep is embedded in the constraint lattice

> *Reviewer Guidance:* "The system replaces authored prep with guided storytelling. Every card draw is improvisation with guardrails."

3.3 Mechanical Simplicity vs. Narrative Sophistication

Misconception: "Simple mechanics = shallow stories"
Reality: Sophistication emerges from constraint interaction

> *Reviewer Guidance:* "Like jazz with a vast repertoire, the same simple rules that handle Session 1 magic effortlessly scale to manage Session 50 world-changing consequences."

4 Evaluation Methodology

4.1 Progressive Complexity Assessment

1. **Tier I Play** (30–40 XP): Evaluate session-to-session narrative flow with minimal subsystems
2. **Tier III Play** (90–150 XP): Assess how character growth naturally expands storytelling scope
3. **Tier V Play** (220+ XP): Examine how simple rules handle complex, multi-threaded narratives

4.2 Mastery Curve Analysis

Key Metric: Mastery effort should decrease as narrative complexity increases

Success Indicators:

- Session 1: Clear, engaging storytelling with minimal reference
- Session 10: Comfortable integration of multiple subsystems
- Session 30: Mechanics become invisible; focus entirely on narrative

5 What to Look For

5.1 Narrative-First Design

- Every mechanical element should serve story consequences

- Player agency should manifest through narrative choices, not optimization
- GM authority should prioritize “what happens” over “what are the rules”

5.2 Constraint-Based Creativity

- Random elements should create coherent, not chaotic, storytelling
- Regional generators should maintain thematic consistency while enabling variety
- Mechanical constraints should inspire creativity, not limit options

5.3 Scalable Sophistication

- Same core mechanics should handle intimate scenes and epic narratives
- Character progression should expand narrative possibilities, not mechanical options
- World complexity should emerge from player actions, not pre-authored content

6 Red Flags vs. Design Features

6.1 Actual Red Flags

- Mechanics that require constant reference during play
- Subsystems that don’t integrate naturally with core philosophy
- Progression that adds mechanical burden rather than narrative freedom

6.2 Misinterpreted Design Features

- **High content volume** = Creative resource library, not mastery burden
- **Multiple magic paths** = Narrative vocabulary expansion, not mechanical complexity
- **Regional generators** = Inspiration engines, not reference requirements

7 Recommended Review Approach

7.1 Session 1–3 Evaluation

Focus on:

- How quickly engaging stories emerge

- Clarity of core mechanical principles
- Integration of generated content into coherent narratives

7.2 Session 10+ Evaluation

Assess:

- How naturally complexity emerges from player choices
- Integration of multiple subsystems without mechanical overhead
- Evolution from "using rules" to "telling stories"

7.3 Long-term Assessment

Consider:

- Whether the system grows with narrative ambition
- If mastery effort genuinely decreases over time
- How world complexity emerges organically from play

8 The Core Truth

Fate's Edge succeeds not by being simple, but by being **designed for simplicity to emerge naturally from complex storytelling**. Evaluate it not as a comprehensive system to master, but as a storytelling partnership that grows in sophistication at exactly the same rate your table develops narrative ambition.

> **This isn't a game you learn – it's a storytelling evolution you grow into.**

Part II

Mechanics Breakdown

9 The Core Philosophy: Beyond Success/Failure

Most RPGs reduce outcomes to a binary: did you succeed or fail? Fate's Edge rejects this. Instead, it asks: *What happens next?* This single question reshapes every mechanic.

The design mantra: **Every roll must move the story forward—no matter the result.** Even a "failure" creates new opportunities, while success often introduces complications. This eliminates dead ends and ensures the narrative constantly evolves.

Why this matters to strategists: The system transforms dice from pass/fail meters into narrative catalysts. Your goal isn't to maximize success rate—it's to manage the flow of consequences so that both triumphs and setbacks drive meaningful story.

9.1 Design Rationale: Why d10s and the 6–9/10 Split

The choice of d10s with successes on 6–9 (1 success) and 10 (2 successes) strikes a deliberate balance:

- **Clean 0.6 expected successes per die** – easy to scale (4 dice = 2.4 expected successes).
- **Natural 10s are exciting** – they occur 10% of the time per die and double the output, creating memorable spikes without breaking probability.
- **1s generate Story Beats** – exactly 10% chance, same as 10s, creating a symmetric risk/reward lever.
- **Rejected alternatives:** d6 pools (too coarse), d20 modifiers (too linear), dice pool with variable target numbers (slower at table).

9.2 Design Rationale: Position Instead of DV Modifiers

Changing Position (Dominant/Controlled/Desperate) rather than adjusting DV preserves the distinction between **task difficulty** (how hard something is) and **situational risk** (how dangerous the attempt is). A lock is DV 3 whether you're in a quiet room (Dominant) or under fire (Desperate). The re-roll mechanic reshapes the probability distribution without altering the base success threshold, keeping the fiction grounded.

10 The Dice Engine: d10s with Purpose

10.1 How Rolls Work

- Roll a pool of d10s: **Attribute (1–5) + Skill (0–5)**

- Each die showing 6–10 = 1 success; a natural 10 = 2 successes
- Target number: Difficulty Value (DV) from 2 (routine) to 5+ (extreme). Default DV = 3

10.2 Why d10s?

- Clean 50% success chance per die (6–10 = 5 out of 10 faces)
- Enables quick mental math: 4 dice → 50% chance of at least one 10
- The "10 = 2 successes" mechanic creates meaningful variance without extra rolls

10.3 Key Probability Insight

With 4 dice (a common sweet spot):

- Chance of at least one success: 93.75% (only 6.25% miss rate)
- Chance of at least one 10: 34.4% (triggers bonus effects)
- Chance of rolling a 1 (for GM): 34.4% (gives the GM narrative leverage)

Strategic implication: The first points in attributes/skills give huge returns (going from 2→3 dice cuts miss rate from 25% → 12.5%). Beyond 4 dice, diminishing returns kick in sharply—miss rate drops from 6.25% → 3.9% for 5 dice, but GM leverage increases significantly. Smart players cap raw dice at 4 and use positioning to boost effective pool size.

11 Position: The Tactical Lever

Position (Dominant/Controlled/Desperate) doesn't just modify difficulty—it reshapes your probability distribution before you roll:

Position	Narrative Frame	Mechanical Effect
Dominant	You press your advantage	Re-roll one failure
Controlled	Balanced, normal risk	No re-rolls
Desperate	You act under duress	Re-roll one success

11.1 What this does mathematically

- **Dominant**: Cuts the left tail of your success distribution. Reduces chance of zero successes dramatically (e.g., 25% → 6.25% at 2 dice).
- **Desperate**: Increases volatility – more likely to get extreme results (0 or 2+ successes). Favors high-skill players who can turn a re-rolled 6 into a 10.

Critical nuance: Position adjustments stack as dice. If already Dominant, further improvements become +1 die (not additional re-rolls). This prevents abuse while keeping positioning meaningful.

11.2 Design Rationale: Why No Fixed Initiative

Fate's Edge uses fiction-first spotlighting instead of cyclic initiative. This:

- Rewards player descriptions and tactical positioning.
- Allows GMs to escalate tension by interrupting actions.
- Avoids the ”I go, you go” stall when players have high dice pools (success is certain, but order still matters).

12 The Outcome Matrix: Four Paths Forward

Every roll lands in one of four states—all create narrative momentum:

Roll Result	**Outcome**
Successes $\geq$ DV, SB = 0	Clean Success. Achieve intent without complication.
Successes $\geq$ DV, SB ¿ 0	Success with SB. Achieve intent; GM spends SB for a twist.
0 ¡ Successes ¡ DV	Partial. Make progress; player gains 1 Boon.
Successes = 0	Miss. No progress; player gains 2 Boons; GM escalates with SB.

Why this eliminates dead ends:

- A Partial isn't failure—it's meaningful progress (e.g., "The lock is stiff but you think you can get it if you keep trying").
- A Miss generates resources (Boons) that let you influence the next roll.
- The GM must spend SB to complicate the situation—nothing is ever "nothing happens."

Strategic depth: The system creates a resource loop:

- Boons (from Partial/Miss) let you re-roll dice or improve position
- Story Beats (SB) (from 1s rolled) let the GM introduce complications
- Smart players embrace small failures early to stockpile Boons for critical moments—but Boons cap at 5 and reset partially between scenes, preventing hoarding.

13 Resources: Boons (Player) and Story Beats (GM)

13.1 Boons: Your Tactical Reserve

Boons represent momentum, luck, and narrative leverage. Spend them to:

- Re-roll a single die (1 Boon)
- Improve position by one step before rolling (1 Boon)
- Activate an off-screen Asset (1 Boon)
- Convert 2 Boons → 1 XP (once per session, max 2 XP/session)

The XP conversion trap: Converting Boons to XP is rarely optimal. One Boon via re-roll gives 0.4 expected successes—often worth more than the XP gained from those successes. Only convert when:

- You're at the 5-Boon cap (about to lose excess)
- The session is ending (Boons reset to 2)

Optimal use: Always keep 1 Boon for critical re-rolls. Spending 1 Boon to improve position (e.g., Controlled → Dominant) before a big roll is often better than re-rolling after—it affects your entire pool.

13.2 Story Beats: GM's Narrative Fuel

Every 1 rolled gives the GM 1 Story Beat. Spend SB to:

- **1 SB**: Minor complication (noise, distraction, +1 timer segment)
- **2 SB**: Moderate complication (alarm raised, lose advantage, worsen position)
- **3+ SB**: Major complication (reinforcements, scene shift, broken asset)

The high-level shift: At lower tiers, the GM spends SB sparingly (1–2/scene). At tiers III+ (90+ XP), players routinely roll 6–8 dice—generating 0.47–0.57 expected SB per roll. In a 4-player round, that's 2–2.3 SB generated. Smart GMs spend this aggressively.

14 Harm and Fatigue: The Anti-Death Spiral

Most games punish injury with worsening rolls—a death spiral. Fate's Edge does the opposite:

- **Fatigue**: Tracks exertion (max = Body). Each point worsens position (Dominant → Desperate). If already Desperate, each fatigue = –1 die.

- **Harm**: Injury severity (1 = –1 die on related actions, 2 = –2 dice on most actions, 3 = incapacitated).

The key innovation: **Taking harm clears all fatigue.** The shock of a wound resets exhaustion—creating dramatic swings (e.g., a fatigued character who takes harm suddenly finds second wind).

14.1 Armor's Role

Armor converts harm to fatigue:

Armor Type	**Harm 1**	**Harm 2**	**Harm 3**
Light	Fatigue 1	Harm 1 + Fatigue 1	Harm 2 + Fatigue 1
Medium	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 1	Harm 2 + Fatigue 1
Heavy	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 1	Fatigue 2

Strategic implication: Heavy armor turns lethal blows into manageable exhaustion—but is less efficient against multiple small hits. Smart players:

- Use heavy armor against expected high-damage threats
- Accept light/medium armor for versatile threat environments
- Sometimes seek low-risk harm (e.g., trapping a hand in a door) to reset fatigue when overwhelmed

14.2 Design Rationale: The Roller-Coaster (Harm Clears Fatigue)

This anti-death spiral encourages aggressive play. A wounded character is not less effective; they are refreshed (Fatigue cleared) but with a new injury that imposes a narrow penalty. This models adrenaline and desperation, and it makes healing meaningful – removing Harm also removes the Fatigue you might have accumulated.

15 Timers: Visible Tension Tracking

Timers track progress toward an event (4–10 segments). They advance via:

- Misses/Partials (often +1 segment)
- GM spending SB (usually 1 segment per SB)
- Player actions (e.g., successful skill checks)

Why they matter strategically: Timers turn abstract threats into tangible resources. A "Barrow Collapse [6]" timer means:

- You have 6 “safe” actions before the entrance seals
- Each failed roll or GM SB spend brings you closer to disaster
- Smart players treat timers like countdown timers—allocating actions to delay or accelerate based on goals

High-level insight: At higher tiers, timers become the primary threat meter. The GM doesn’t just add complications—they use timers to make pressure visible and inevitable. Players must manage timer state alongside their resources.

16 Magic: The TAGS System

Free casting uses TAGS (keywords) to build spells. DV is calculated simply:

$$\text{DV} = 1 + \text{number of TAGS}$$

with dangerous TAGS (Leap, Fold, Gate, Transform, Dominate) adding +2 DV each.

16.1 Example Spells

Spell	**TAGS**	**DV**
Light	[Illuminate]	2
Heal	[Heal]	2
Shield of Air	[Air][Defend]	3
Fire Wall	[Fire][Wall]	3
Teleport	[Fold] (dangerous)	1+2=3

16.2 Why this system wins

- Transforms spell design into a cost-benefit equation
- Rewards creativity within clear constraints (e.g., “Firebolt” = [Fire] DV 2; add [Ranged] for distance = DV 3)
- Scales risk: More TAGS = higher DV = more chance of backlash
- Backlash is thematic (fire backlash = smoke → blaze; earth = dust → fissure)

Smart caster play: Build minimum TAGS for effect, then:

- Use positioning to improve effective DV
- Accept manageable backlash (e.g., fatigue 1) for high-impact spells
- Save high-risk spells for moments when you can mitigate consequences

16.3 Design Rationale: Variable Obligation Costs for Rites

Unlike free casting, Rites have a listed Obligation cost (e.g., 6 segments). The DV formula ‘max(Obligation Spirit, Tier)‘ ensures that Spirit directly reduces the difficulty of the roll, making the attribute valuable for casters without dominating the dice economy. This creates a meaningful trade-off: invest in Spirit for easier Rites, or in other attributes for broader utility.

17 Advancement: The XP Economy

XP costs scale to encourage meaningful choices:

Improvement	**Cost**	**Downtime**
Attribute increase	new rating × 3 XP	new rating (days)
Skill increase	new level × 2 XP	new level (days)
Minor Asset (tool, contact)	4 XP	1 day
Standard Asset (safehouse, network)	8 XP	1 week
Major Asset (fortress, guildhall)	12 XP	1 month
Minor Talent (edge case)	2–4 XP	3–10 days
Major Talent (core ability)	5–8 XP	1–2 weeks

17.1 Design rationale

- Attributes cost more because they affect multiple skills (e.g., high Body aids melee, athletics, stealth)
- Skills cost less because they’re narrower in application
- Creates natural progression: Broad attribute foundation → Skill specialization → Talent mastery

17.2 Diminishing returns in action

- Raising an attribute from 4→5: 15 XP for +1 die on 3–5 skills
- Raising a skill from 4→5: 10 XP for +1 die on only that skill
- Optimal path: Max key attributes to 4 first (60 XP for all four at 4), then specialize skills to 3–4, then take talents

17.3 Tiers of play (XP ranges)

- **Novice (0–40)**: Local reputation, prestige locked
- **Seasoned (41–90)**: Regional notice, prestige abilities unlock

- **Veteran (91–150)**: National influence, second follower slot suggested
- **Paragon (151–220)**: Movers and shakers, rivals emerge
- **Mythic (221+)**: Legendary status, kingdoms respond

At Veteran+: You'll regularly roll 8+ dice. The game responds not by inflating DV, but by making the GM's SB spend more impactful—reinforcements arrive faster, complications cascade, and success requires meaningful sacrifice.

18 Subsystem Interaction Analysis

Understanding how subsystems overlap is key for designers.

- **Obligation & Spirit:** Obligation capacity = Spirit + Presence. Rite DV also uses Spirit in the formula ‘max(Obligation Spirit, Tier)‘. Thus Spirit is a ”super-attribute” for magic users, reducing both roll difficulty and capacity pressure. This is intentional – magical investment should feel powerful.
- **Corruption & Spirit:** Cantors use Spirit only for their Corruption timer size, not for their Performance rolls. This makes Cantors MAD (Wits, Presence, Spirit) but gives them a safety valve (larger timer). Balanced by the fact that they never pay Obligation.
- **Leash & Wards:** Summoners” Leash ticks when a spirit crosses a ‘[WARD]‘ (tick = ward's DV). This creates natural tension between summoners and abjurers – a ‘[WARD]‘ is both a defense and a tax on the summoner.
- **Assets & Downtime:** Upkeep costs (XP or action) compete with training and recovery. The Over-Stack rule further discourages pre-scene asset stacking, forcing players to choose which assets to keep Flourishing.
- **Follower & Bond economy:** Followers grant assist dice; Bonds grant Boons when invoked. Neither replaces the other – assists improve probability, Boons provide rerolls/position upgrades. They stack multiplicatively.

19 Balance Tuning Notes (Intentional Asymmetries)

The following asymmetries are deliberate design choices; do not ”fix” them without understanding the consequences.

20 Playtest Findings (Emergent Behaviors)

From dozens of sessions across all tiers:

Asymmetry	Why It's Balanced
Body affects Fatigue track; Wits/Presence have no secondary scaling.	Combat characters need resource gates; social and scouting rely on player creativity and positioning, not raw stats.
Spirit reduces Rite DV and increases Obligation capacity, but Cantors don't use Spirit for rolls.	Magic users pay a steep attribute tax; Cantors trade Obligation for Corruption and are MAD to compensate.
Heavy armor is inefficient against multiple small hits but best against single big hits.	Encourages tactical armor choice – heavy for bosses, light/medium for skirmishes.
Over-Stack only triggers on pre-scene advantages, not mid-scene creativity.	Rewards improvisation; preparation has a cost but is still viable.
Rites have variable Obligation (4–8) but DV formula keeps rolls achievable.	Higher Obligation rites are more powerful; Spirit investment directly reduces their difficulty, creating a natural progression.
Boons reset to 2 per scene; conversion to XP is capped.	Prevents hoarding and XP farming; forces active Boon spending.

- **Low tiers (I–II):** Players initially hoarded Boons to convert to XP. Adding the per-session cap (reset to 2) and low XP conversion limit (2/session) fixed this. Now Boons are actively spent.

- **Mid tiers (II–III):** Groups discovered that a Partial is not a failure – they began embracing Partials to generate Boons for upcoming rolls. This created a healthy risk cycle.

- **High tiers (III–IV):** Players stopped rolling because success was nearly certain. The shift to SB spending as the primary difficulty lever (timers, complications) brought tension back. GMs learned to spend SB on narrative twists, not just penalties.

- **Summoners:** Playtesters thought Boon Finesse (clear 1 Leash tick per round for 1 Boon) would make spirits permanent. However, at epic tiers Boons are rare (Misses nearly impossible), so the problem self-corrected. At low tiers Boons are plentiful, but spirits are weak – balanced.

- **Cantors:** Players initially avoided Corruption blooms, fearing the burden. After emphasizing that the boon is a power spike, players began planning blooms as "level-ups." The Tier reset rule (set current segments to Tier, not zero) caused confusion – we later changed it to reset to zero (SRD) to match other timers.

- **Assets & Followers:** At high tiers, players shifted XP from personal attributes to followers and assets. A Cap 3 follower provides +3 assist dice for 9 XP, cheaper than raising an attribute from 4→5 (15 XP for +1 die). This emergent behavior is intended.

21 Design Patterns and Anti-patterns

21.1 Patterns (Reusable)

- **Resource Cycle:** Partial → 1 Boon → spend Boon to improve Position → fewer failures → fewer Boons. Closes the loop and encourages active resource use.
- **Cost vs. Consequence:** Obligation (tracked, can be cleared) vs. Backlash (immediate, thematic). Different magic paths use different risk profiles.
- **Visible Tension:** Timers advance on GM SB – the GM is forced to show pressure building (e.g., "Reinforcements timer ticks +1").
- **Anti-Death Spiral:** Harm clears Fatigue. Model: injury as a reset, not a penalty.

21.2 Anti-patterns (Avoid)

- **Roll to avoid rolling:** A spell or talent that prevents all future rolls (e.g., "auto-succeed on all stealth checks"). Instead, use timers or escalating costs (e.g., "Each use advances a Suspicion timer").
- **Permanent +1 die talents:** They devalue positioning and Assistance. Use conditional bonuses ("+1 die when you have advantage").
- **Resource conversion loops:** Boons → XP → Boons? We capped XP conversion and reset Boons per scene to prevent farming.

Part III

Tiered Heuristics

22 Introduction to Tiered Play

The following heuristics are derived from probability simulations and extensive playtesting. They provide optimal strategies for each tier of play (I–IV), grounded in the game's core design principle: **DV does not inflate; instead, SB and Boon scarcity drive difficulty.**

22.1 Common Assumptions

- Default DV = 3 (routine) to 4 (challenging)
- Position starts Controlled unless fiction dictates otherwise
- Players use bonds and assets as intended
- GM spends SB aggressively, following the SB spend tables

22.2 Annotated Play Example: Tier I

Scenario: Lyra (Wits 3 + Stealth 2 = 5 dice) sneaks past a guard (DV 3). The GM sets Position = Controlled.

1. Lyra rolls [9,6,4,2,1] → successes: 9,6 = 2 successes (DV 3 → Partial). She gains 1 Boon. The 1 gives the GM 1 SB.
2. The GM spends 1 SB: ”The lock clicks open, but the last pin squeals. The guard turns his head.”
3. Lyra now has 1 Boon. She uses it on her next roll (to hide) to upgrade Position to Dominant.
4. Probability analysis: With 5 dice, chance of Partial is 30%, Miss 3%. The Boon from Partial funds the next roll's Dominant position, creating a sustainable cycle.

Takeaway: Embrace Partials as Boon generators.

23 Tier I (0–40 XP) Optimal Heuristics

23.1 Combat – Melee vs. Ranged

Scenario: 1v1 against a bandit (Cap 2, Defense DV 3, Harm 1 per hit). Tier I character has Body 3 + Melee 2 = 5 dice.

Dice	P(success ≥3)	P(Miss 0)	Expected SB
5	72%	3%	0.5

Heuristic: 5 dice gives 72% success rate. For high reliability (≥85%), need 6 dice (Body 3 + Melee 3).

Optimal Tier I melee build: Body 3, Melee 3 (6 dice). Cost: Body 3 (9 XP) + Melee 3 (6 XP) = 15 XP. Leaves room for other skills.

Position impact: Dominant (re-roll one failure) effectively adds 1.5 dice. Desperate hurts reliable characters more than it helps – avoid unless you have Boons to spare.

Boons: One Boon spent to re-roll a failure on a 5-die pool increases success rate from 72% → 82% (worth 10% absolute). Best used when you have at least one success and need one more.

Takeaway: At Tier I, prioritize getting your primary combat skill to 3 (6 XP) and attribute to 3 (9 XP). Don't spread thin.

23.2 Social – Persuasion

Scenario: Convince a guard to let you pass (DV 3). Presence 2 + Sway 2 = 4 dice.

Dice	P(success ≥3)	P(Partial)	P(Miss)
4	54%	38%	8%

Heuristic: 4 dice is unreliable. Spend a Boon to improve Position (Controlled → Dominant) before rolling: re-roll one failure effectively adds 1 die, raising success to 66%. Better than re-rolling after.

Optimal social build: Presence 3 (9 XP) + Sway 3 (6 XP) = 15 XP. 6 dice gives 87% success. But Tier I resources are tight. For secondary role, Presence 2 + Sway 2 (4 dice) + Boon for Dominant is acceptable.

23.3 Stealth

Scenario: Sneak past a sentry. DV 3, Wits 3 + Stealth 2 = 5 dice.

Heuristic: 5 dice at Controlled gives 72% success. Sentries often have Notice pools of 3–4 dice; opposed roll? Fate's Edge uses DV set by GM, not opposed. So 5 dice is solid.

Optimal: Wits 3 (9 XP) + Stealth 3 (6 XP) = 15 XP gives 6 dice (87%). Overkill? Not if you're the scout.

Position tricks: Dominant is huge for stealth – one Miss can alert the whole camp. Spend 1 Boon before rolling to upgrade position.

23.4 Investigation / Lore

Scenario: Research a forgotten ritual. DV 3, Wits 3 + Lore 2 = 5 dice.

Heuristic: Same as stealth. But note: failures here generate SB that GM can use for narrative twists (e.g., you find the info but also alert a guardian). Acceptable.

Optimal: If this is your niche, Lore 3 (6 XP) is cheap. Wits 3 + Lore 3 = 6 dice.

23.5 Travel / Survival

Scenario: Navigate a broken road in Acasia. DV 3, Wits 2 + Survival 2 = 4 dice.

Heuristic: 4 dice → 54% success. Travel often allows assistance (party member helps → +1 die up to +3 max). With 2 helpers, you can reach 6 dice (87%). Don't invest heavily in Survival unless you're the guide.

23.6 Resource Management – Boons

- You gain 1 Boon on a Partial, 2 Boons on a Miss. Hold up to 5 Boons, reset to 2 at scene end.
- **Optimal Boon use**:
    1. **Before rolling**: Spend 1 Boon to upgrade Position (Controlled → Dominant) – best value.
    2. **After rolling**: Reroll a failure – second best.
    3. Activate Asset – situational.
    4. Convert to XP – only at session end if you're at cap.
- **Heuristic**: Never let a Partial's Boon go to waste – use it on the next roll to improve position. Cycle: Partial → gain 1 Boon → spend it on next roll for Dominant → higher success rate → fewer Misses.
- Boons from Misses (2) are painful, but if you have Boons stored, you can recover. Misses are more acceptable when you have 2+ Boons already.

23.7 Damage Output vs. Survival

Tier I character: 3 Harm capacity (Harm 3 = incapacitated). Body 3 gives Fatigue track size 3.

Armor choice (from earlier table): Light armor fine if high Body (Fatigue track 4+). Medium best for all-rounders. Heavy for tanks.

Damage output: At Tier I, max damage is 2 Harm per hit (with a 10). To down a Tier I foe (3 Harm) in 1–2 hits, need +1 Effect or critical hits.

Takeaway: +1 Effect (from talents or positioning) is more valuable than +1 die for damage. A shove to make prone (gives +1 Effect) is often better than attacking twice.

23.8 Timer Management

Scenario: 6-segment "Reinforcements Arrive" timer. Each failed roll ticks +1.

Heuristic: Treat timers as resources. If you have high dice pools (≥6), you can risk ticking the timer because you'll likely succeed. If you have low pools (4), avoid rolls that advance timers – use alternate approaches (stealth, negotiation) that don't trigger the timer.

Timer size determination (from generators): 2–5 rank = 4 segments; 6–10 = 6; J/Q/K = 8; A = 10. At Tier I, 6-segment timers are common.

23.9 Skill Synergies

At Tier I, focus on 2–3 key skills at level 2–3. Optimal spread for 32–36 XP build:

Role	Primary Attribute	Key Skills (lvl 2-3)	XP (att+skills)
Fighter	Body 3	Melee 3, Athletics 2, Command 1	21
Face	Presence 3	Sway 3, Insight 2, Deception 1	21
Scout	Wits 3	Stealth 3, Survival 2, Subterfuge 1	21
Scholar	Wits 3	Lore 3, Arcana 2, Investigation 1	21
Healer	Spirit 3	Medicine 3, Survival 2, Insight 1	21

21 XP on core attributes+skills leaves 11–15 XP for a minor talent (2–4 XP), a minor asset (4 XP), and/or a second skill at 2 (4 XP). This is the sweet spot.

23.10 Optimal Starting Build Template (Tier I, 32–36 XP)

```
Attributes: Primary 3, Secondary 2, Tertiary 2, Dump 1 (cost: 9+6+6+3 = 24 XP)
Skills: Primary skill 3 (6 XP), Secondary skill 2 (4 XP), Tertiary skill 1 (2 XP) = 12 XP
Total: 36 XP -- exactly at max.
```

If you want an asset or talent, drop a skill level.

23.11 Tier I Heuristics Summary

1. Target 6 dice for primary action (Attribute 3 + Skill 3) → 87% success at DV 3.
2. 5 dice (3+2) is acceptable (72%) – use Boons to upgrade position.
3. Spend Boons before rolling to upgrade Position – best ROI.
4. Don't hoard Boons – you reset to 2 at scene end.
5. Embrace Partials – they give a Boon and keep the story moving.
6. Misses are acceptable when you have Boons to buffer, but avoid on critical rolls.

7. Use assistance – helping adds up to +3 dice.
8. Timers are timers – track visibly. Use high-dice rolls to advance safely.
9. Armor choice: Medium is best for most Tier I characters.
10. Skill spread: 3/2/1 optimal for 36 XP. For an asset, drop to 3/1/1 or 2/2/1.

24 Tier II (41–90 XP) Optimal Heuristics

24.1 Combat

Scenario: Fighting a Cap 3 elite (Defense DV 4, Harm 2 per hit). Tier II baseline: Body 3 + Melee 3 = 6 dice, often boosted to 7–8 via talents/assets.

Dice	P(success ≥4)	P(Partial)	P(Miss)	Exp SB
6	59%	38%	3%	0.6
7	68%	30%	2%	0.7
8	76%	23%	1%	0.8

Heuristic: Want at least 7 dice for 68% success against DV 4. 8 dice (76%) is reliable.

Optimal Tier II melee: Body 4 (12 XP from 3→4) + Melee 4 (8 XP from 3→4) = 20 XP upgrade from Tier I. Total dice = 8.

Position impact: Dominant on 8 dice pushes success to 87% against DV 4. Desperate risky.

Boons: One Boon for Dominant before rolling still optimal. Rerolling single failure on 8 dice less efficient (76% → 82%).

Talent synergy: "Battle Instincts" (reroll failed defense) huge. "Exceptional Coordination" (follower gives +4 dice) pushes to 12 dice (overkill but fun).

24.2 Ranged Combat

Similar dice math. Ranged often allows Controlled/Dominant from high ground. Ammo management via Supply timer. Minor asset "Quiver of Endless Arrows" (4 XP) worthwhile.

24.3 Social – High-Stakes Negotiation

Scenario: DV 4, Presence 3 + Sway 3 = 6 dice → 59% success. Too low. Upgrade to Presence 4 + Sway 3 (7 dice → 68%) or Presence 3 + Sway 4 (7 dice). Better: Presence 4 + Sway 4 (8 dice → 76%).

Optimal social: Presence 4 (12 XP) + Sway 4 (8 XP) = 20 XP. Add "Silver Tongue" (4 XP) for +1 die → 9 dice (83%). Social assets: "Noble Contact" (Minor, 4 XP) or "Diplomatic Papers" grant +1 Position.

24.4 Stealth – Infiltration

Scenario: Sneak past magical ward (DV 4). Wits 4 + Stealth 3 = 7 dice → 68%. Acceptable. For DV 5 (magical ward + sentry), need 8–9 dice.

Optimal stealth: Wits 4 + Stealth 4 (8 dice). "Shadow's Cloak" asset (advantage in dim light) adds effective +2 dice. Talent "Shadow Dance" (10 XP) lets re-enter stealth after kill – very strong.

24.5 Investigation / Lore

Scenario: DV 4, Wits 4 + Lore 3 = 7 dice (68%). Often take extra time (upgrade position) or use "Library" asset (Minor, +1 die). Optimal: Wits 4 + Lore 4 = 8 dice (76%). "Lorekeeper" talent (4 XP) invaluable for plot-critical moments.

24.6 Travel / Survival

Scenario: DV 4, Wits 3 + Survival 3 = 6 dice → 59%. But group assistance can push to 9 dice (87%). Survival 3 sufficient if party cooperates. Use Guide's Braid or similar assets to reduce DV.

24.7 Resource Management – Boons

At Tier II, larger dice pools roll more 1s: 0.6–0.8 SB per roll. GM will spend aggressively. Boon sources: Partials (main) and bonds. Misses rare.

Heuristic: Boon scarcity increases. Use Boons for Dominant position rather than re-rolls. Attempt lower-stakes roll first to generate a Boon (Partial), then use that Boon to upgrade position on critical roll.

24.8 Damage Output vs. Survival

Tier II foes: Harm 3–4, may have Armor 1. Player Harm capacity: Body 3 → Fatigue 3. With medium armor, convert Harm 2 → Fatigue 1.

Damage output: 8 dice + good weapon (+1 Harm from talent) → expected 2–3 Harm per hit. Down Tier II foe in 1–2 hits.

Optimal damage talents: "Backstab" (8 XP), "Radiant Smite", "Blood Frenzy". Defensive: "Battle Instincts", "Unnatural Resilience".

24.9 Timer Management

Timers often 8 segments. Use high-dice characters to advance primary timer, lower-dice to manipulate secondary timers via non-dice actions (bribes, distractions).

24.10 Skill Synergies & Build Templates (70–80 XP)

XP budget from Tier I (36 XP) plus 34–44 XP earned = 70–80 XP.

Upgrade priorities:

1. Raise primary attribute to 4 (12 XP)
2. Raise primary skill to 4 (8 XP)
3. Raise secondary attribute to 3 (9 XP)
4. Major talent (6–10 XP)
5. Minor asset (4 XP) or Cap 3 follower (9 XP)

Example Fighter (80 XP): From Tier I baseline, upgrade Body 3→4 (12), Melee 3→4 (8), Wits 2→3 (9). Add "Battle Instincts" (6) and minor asset (4) = 39 XP from Tier I. Left 41 XP for Presence, follower, etc.

Example Face (80 XP): Presence 3→4 (12), Sway 3→4 (8), Wits 2→3 (9). Add "Silver Tongue" (4) and "Diplomatic Papers" (4) = 37 XP from Tier I. Left 43 XP.

24.11 Tier II Heuristics Summary

1. Target 8 dice for primary actions (Attribute 4 + Skill 4) → 76% vs DV 4.
2. Boons scarcer (Misses rare). Use to upgrade Position, not re-rolls.
3. Partials are main Boon source – a Partial is success with cost; take the Boon and use next roll.
4. SB generation increases (0.8–1.0 per roll). Expect regular complications.
5. Get a major talent (6–10 XP) – affordable and defining.
6. Raise secondary attribute to 3 – broadens versatility.
7. Assets matter – Minor asset (4 XP) gives free off-screen effect or +1 die situationally.
8. Followers (Cap 3, 9 XP) add +3 assist dice – very strong.
9. Timers often 8 segments – plan 8–10 actions. High-dice advance, low-dice manipulate.
10. Defense matters – enemies hit harder. Take defensive talent or invest in medium/heavy armor.

25 Tier III (91–150 XP) Optimal Heuristics

Core GM Principle: Do not artificially inflate DV. Keep standard DV at 3. Instead, spend the glut of SB (from larger dice pools) on more pressure, interesting twists, and cascading complications.

Consequence: Players succeed more often, but every success comes with a cost. Boons become scarce because Misses are rare. Characters are more powerful (more dice) but more brittle (less Boon cushion).

25.1 The Probability Shift

Dice	P(success $\geq$3)	P(Partial)	P(Miss)	Exp SB
10	99.8%	¡0.2%	¡0.1%	1.0

Interpretation: You will almost never Miss or Partial. Nearly every roll is Clean Success or Success with SB. Boons from failures vanish.

25.2 SB Abundance

With 10 dice, 1 SB per roll. 4-player round → 4 SB per round. GM spends aggressively.

Heuristic: Every success will likely have a cost. Expect every rolled action to generate a complication. Plan backup plans, escape routes, redundant assets.

25.3 Boon Scarcity – Strategic Implications

Boon sources: bonds (1–2 per session), GM awards. Miss rate near zero.

Optimal Boon use:

- Never spend on re-rolling (you already succeed).
- Never convert to XP (waste).
- Spend to upgrade Position (Controlled → Dominant) to reduce expected 1s.
- Spend to activate Assets – primary use.

25.4 Position – SB Mitigation

Dominant reduces expected 1s by 30%. Desperate increases 1s → avoid.

25.5 Timer Management

Timers size 8–10, multiple simultaneous. GM ticks timers with SB. You cannot out-roll timers. Use assets and narrative actions to manipulate them.

25.6 Damage and Survival – Rocket Tag

Tier IV foes: Harm 5–6, Armor 2. First strike wins. Build for assassination or unkillable defense.

25.7 Skill Synergies – Diminishing Returns

Beyond 10 dice, gains microscopic. Stop at Attribute 5 + Skill 5 = 10 dice. Add Cap 3 follower (+3 assist) = effective 13 dice (cap). Invest spare XP in talents, major assets, Cap 4–5 followers, prestige abilities.

25.8 Assets and Followers – Force Multipliers

At Tier III, have at least one Standard asset and one Cap 3–4 follower.

25.9 Example Build Tier III (120 XP)

From Tier II (80 XP), add 40 XP: Body 4→5 (15), Melee 4→5 (10), Battle Instincts (6), Cap 3 Follower (9) = 40 XP. Final dice: Body 5 + Melee 5 = 10 dice; with follower assist +3 = 13 effective.

25.10 Tier III Heuristics Summary

1. Success is guaranteed. Question is "at what cost?"
2. SB abundant – expect complications on every roll.
3. Boons extremely scarce – hoard for defensive use (upgrading Position).
4. Dominant position mandatory – reduces expected 1s. Desperate is a trap.
5. Timers escalate rapidly – use assets to delay/reverse, not dice.
6. Avoid damage, don't soak it – invest in defensive talents and surprise attacks.
7. Dice past 10 give diminishing returns – stop at 10. Invest in +Effect talents and narrative assets.
8. Followers are cheap dice – Cap 3 (9 XP) gives +3 assist better than Attribute 4→5 (15 XP for +1 die).
9. Assets manipulate timers – Standard asset (8 XP) can negate a complication per session.

10. Game shifts from “can I succeed?” to “how much will this cost me?” Embrace the cost – it’s the source of drama.

26 Tier IV (151–220 XP) Optimal Heuristics

26.1 Probability Landscape

Dice	P(success ≥3)	P(Partial)	P(Miss)	Exp SB
12	99.98%	¡0.02%	0.0001%	1.2

Success absolute. No Partials, no Misses. Boons only from bonds and GM awards (3–6 per session).

26.2 SB Abundance – GM Toolkit

12 dice → 1.2 SB per roll → 5 SB per round. GM spends 2–4 SB per complication, often pooling SB from multiple rolls into major twists (4+ SB events).

26.3 Boon Scarcity – Strategic Implications

Treat each Boon as a minor miracle. Primary use: upgrade Position to reduce SB generation, or activate assets.

26.4 Position – The Only Remaining Lever

Dominant reduces expected 1s from 1.2 to 0.8 (0.4 fewer SB per roll). Significant over session. Always seek Dominant.

26.5 Timer Management – Multiple, Interlocking, Rapid

Three or four timers active simultaneously, size 8–10. GM ticks multiple each round. You cannot out-roll them. Use assets to tick timers backward, sacrifice minor assets to pause timers, split party to manage different timers.

26.6 Damage and Survival – Rocket Tag

Tier IV foes: Harm 5–6, Armor 2, multiple attacks. Do not engage in fair fights. First strike wins. Build for assassination or unkillable defense.

Defensive talents: “Unbreakable” (ignore all Harm from one attack), “Shadow Form” (intangible), “Final Witness” (redirect killing blow). Offensive: “Deathblow” (triple Harm from stealth), “Absolute Judgment” (+3 dice), “Market Tyrant” (cripple logistics).

26.7 Skill Synergies – Diminishing Returns

Beyond 12 dice, gains microscopic. Stop at Attribute 5 + Skill 5 = 10 dice. Add Cap 3 follower = effective 13 dice. Spare XP (80–150 XP beyond Tier III) into multiple talents, major assets, Cap 4–5 followers, prestige abilities.

26.8 Assets and Followers – True Power

At Tier IV, have at least two Standard assets, one Major asset, and one Cap 4–5 follower. Your character sheet reflects sphere of influence, not personal stats.

26.9 Example Build – Tier IV Commander (200 XP)

From Tier III (120 XP), add 80 XP: Wits 3→4 (12), Presence 2→4 (21), talents (Inspiring Leader 8, Tactical Genius 10), Major Asset "Fortified Keep" (12), Cap 4 Follower "Elite Squad" (16) = 79 XP. Final dice: Body 5 + Melee 5 = 10 dice; squad assist +3 = 13 effective. Command: Presence 3 + Command 4 = 7 dice + squad assist = 10.

26.10 Tier IV Heuristics Summary

1. Success absolute. Game now about managing SB and complications.
2. Boons extremely scarce (3–6 per session). Use only for Position upgrade or asset activation.
3. SB abundant (5+ per round). Expect every action to generate a moderate complication. Plan for cascading failures.
4. Dominant position mandatory – reduces expected 1s by 30%. Desperate is death.
5. Timers rapid and multiple – cannot out-roll. Use assets and narrative actions.
6. Combat is rocket tag – first strike wins. Build for assassination or unkillable defense.
7. Diminishing returns past 12 dice – stop at Attribute 5 + Skill 5 + follower assist. Invest in talents and assets.
8. Assets are primary tool – solve problems without rolling. Major asset worth more than +2 dice.
9. Followers provide cheap dice – Cap 4 (16 XP) gives +3 assist, better than raising Attribute 4→5 (15 XP for +1 die).
10. Embrace the cost – every victory leaves scars, debts, and new enemies. That's the point.

Magic-Specific Heuristics (All Tiers)

Tier I:

- Stick to 1–2 TAGS per spell (DV 2–3). `[HEAL]` cantrip is your most efficient action (removes 1 Fatigue, no backlash risk).
- Save multi-tag spells for desperate moments.
- For Free Casters: Accept minor backlash (Fatigue 1) rather than avoid casting.

Tier II:

- Dangerous tags (Leap, Fold, Gate, Transform, Dominate) cost +2 DV. Only use when you have 2+ Boons to improve Position or reroll.
- Acceptable backlash: Fatigue 1. Unacceptable: Harm or Corruption.
- Runekeepers: Clear Obligation after every session (Act of Service). Never let Obligation exceed Spirit+Presence – Fatigue penalties kill your Position.

Tier III:

- Your dice pool (8–10) makes DV 5 spells reliable. But every 1 generates SB. Cast `[HEAL]` on allies *before* they take Harm – Fatigue removal is cheap; Harm healing is expensive.
- Cantors: Corruption blooms are not failures – they're power spikes. Plan to bloom once per arc. The burden is a story hook, not a punishment.

Social Encounter Heuristics

- **Before rolling**, ask: "What does this NPC want that they haven't said?" A Wits+Insight roll (DV 3) reveals one hidden need. Use it – it can lower DV by 1 for future rolls.
- **Strings are social Boons.** Spend a String to auto-succeed on a minor social request (e.g., "let me through," "tell me a rumor"). Hoard 1–2 Strings for critical moments.
- **Offer a Debt Timer instead of a roll.** When an NPC refuses, say: "I'll owe you." Start a 4-segment Debt Timer . When it fills, you must perform a service – but you get what you want now.
- **Tier III+ social:** You almost never fail. Instead, the GM spends SB to add complications (a witness overhears, a rival is alerted). Accept these – they're the price of success.

Travel and Exploration Heuristics

- **Travel roles:** Always assign a Guide (Wits+Survival). On a success, tick the Travel Timer +1. On a Partial, tick +1 but gain 1 Boon. On a Miss, tick +1 and the GM gains 1 SB.
- **Use followers for independent actions.** A Cap 3 scout can "Scout & Signal" – change the party's next travel Position to Dominant. Cost: mark Exposure +1 on the follower.
- **Weather is Position.** In heavy rain or fog, default travel Position is Desperate. Spend 1 Boon to improve to Controlled (you find a sheltered path).
- **Tier III travel:** You will succeed. The question is how many SB the GM banks. Avoid rolling unless necessary – use Assets (maps, guides) to bypass rolls entirely.

Asset & Follower Status Heuristics

- **Keep Assets at Stable or better.** Flourishing gives +1 die and +1 Yield; Stable is fine. Strained gives no Yield and –1 die – fix it within one downtime.
- **A Collapsed asset is a story hook, not a loss.** Restoring it requires a quest or major downtime. Use it to generate a session's plot (e.g., "The safehouse was seized by the city guard – get it back.")
- **Monitor Follower Loyalty before Fitness.** A Strained follower may still fight but can refuse orders; a Hurt follower (Fitness) is merely less effective. Prioritise loyalty missions (e.g., personal favors, public recognition) over healing.
- **Use Independent Actions sparingly – each one worsens Loyalty or Fitness.** Save Scout & Signal for critical moments (e.g., before a boss fight). For routine scouting, use a Cap 3+ follower's Off-Screen Capability instead (costs 1 SB but no status loss).
- **Delegate Assets to a Cap 4–5 follower only when their Loyalty is Faithful.** If a follower's Loyalty drops to Strained while managing delegated Assets, all those Assets immediately worsen one step. Check Loyalty before every downtime.

Player Trust Heuristics

- **Form a Trust at Tier II or III, not earlier.** Below Tier II, XP is too scarce; pooling 10+ XP delays personal advancement. At Tier III, shared assets become force multipliers.
- **Delegate upkeep to a Cap 5 follower as soon as possible.** A single Cap 5 follower can manage 4 Assets for free (using their own upkeep). This saves the party 4–12 XP per downtime.
- **Never put all Assets under one delegated follower.** If that follower's Loyalty becomes Strained or Broken, all delegated Assets worsen immediately. Split delegation between two Cap 4 followers (2 Assets each) for redundancy.
- **Dissolve the Trust only if the campaign ends or a player leaves permanently.** A dissolved Trust returns no XP; instead, transfer Assets to individuals by paying half their XP cost (or accepting Obligation to a terrestrial patron).

- **Use the Trust pool for one-time emergencies.** With majority agreement, spend 2 XP from the pool to activate a Trust Asset twice in a session (instead of once). This is cheaper than each player spending their own Boons.

Patron and Obligation Heuristics

- **Obligation Capacity = Spirit + Presence.** Never let total Obligation exceed this. Mark Fatigue when you do. If you exceed by 2+, trigger a Patron Intrusion – embrace it as a story hook.
- **Clear Obligation every downtime.** An Act of Service (described scene) clears 1 segment. Do this before accumulating debt.
- **Multiple Patrons (Invoker):** Each Symbol has its own Obligation track. Total Obligation is the sum. If you carry 3 Symbols, you'll hit capacity fast. Specialize in 1–2 Patrons.
- **When to accept a Patron Intrusion:** When the GM says "your Patron demands a task," say yes. It's free adventure fuel. Refusing costs you 1 Fatigue and the Patron may withdraw a Rite until you comply.

Terrestrial Patron Heuristics

- **Accept favors only when the Debt Timer is low (0–2 segments).** A timer at 3+ segments is a ticking bomb – the patron will call in the debt soon.
- **Always clear at least 1 Obligation per downtime.** Terrestrial patrons are less patient than cosmic ones; skipping two cycles may trigger Sanction (e.g., revoked permits, bounty).
- **Use a String before a favor.** If you have a String (e.g., "I did the guild a favor last year"), spend it to reduce the Obligation cost of a new favor by 1 segment.
- **When a Debt Timer fills, offer a counter-proposal.** Patrons are rational. "I can"t assassinate the duke, but I can deliver proof of his embezzlement" may reframe the debt without penalty.
- **Sever ties only if you have a replacement patron.** Losing a Tier 2 patron without a backup leaves you vulnerable. Cultivate at least one other terrestrial patron before burning bridges.

Healing and Recovery Heuristics

- **Use `[HEAL]` after every fight.** One action, DV 2, removes 1 Fatigue. No backlash risk (unless you roll 1s, which give the GM SB – acceptable).
- **Accept Harm to reset Fatigue (the roller-coaster).** If you're at Fatigue 3 (Desperate, –2 dice), a small Harm 1 (e.g., trap, punch) clears Fatigue and leaves you at Harm 1, Fatigue 0. This is a tactical reset – use it.

- **Healing Harm is expensive.** DV 5+ for `[HEAL]+[PURIFY]`. Only do this if the target is at Harm 2 or dying. Otherwise, rest for a week (downtime).
- **Tier III+ healing:** You will succeed. The GM will spend SB on complications (scars, Patron attention). Accept these – they're better than a dead ally.

Combat Positioning and Movement Heuristics

- **Sidestep Strike:** Move one band as part of a melee attack, but Position worsens by one step. Use this to close from Near to Close with a light weapon (+2d) – the extra dice offset the Position penalty.
- **Charge (Full turn):** Move two bands and attack, cost 1 Fatigue, next defense Desperate. Only charge when you have a Boon to improve defense Position, or when you're sure to kill the target.
- **Opportunity attacks:** Leaving Close range without Disengage provokes a free melee attack. Always Disengage (action) unless you have a talent that ignores this (e.g., Tactical Movement).
- **Flanking:** If two allies are in Close with the same enemy, both gain +1 die to melee attacks. Coordinate.

Party Composition Synergy Heuristics

- **Essential roles (Tier I–II):** At least one `[HEAL]` user (removes Fatigue), one scout (Wits+Stealth), one face (Presence+Sway). Combat can be anyone.
- **Essential roles (Tier III+):** At least one Asset manager (keeps safehouse/spy network), one follower commander (Cap 3+ to delegate), one magic user (to handle wards/curses).
- **Skill overlap:** Two characters with Stealth 3+ is better than one with Stealth 5 – you can split the party for infiltration.
- **Bonds:** Ensure every PC has at least one Bond with another PC. That Bond grants 1 Boon per session when invoked. Use it.

GM-Facing Heuristics (Optional)

- **SB spending per scene:** Target 1–2 SB for Tier I, 2–4 for Tier II, 4–6 for Tier III+. Unused SB are wasted pressure.
- **Timer size by tier:** Tier I: 4–6 segments. Tier II: 6–8. Tier III: 8–10. Larger timers = more guaranteed escalation.
- **When to worsen Position:** Do it when the fiction demands it (ambush, bad weather, social faux pas). Do not do it just to raise difficulty – use SB for that.
- **Deck of Consequences:** Draw 1 card per 2 SB spent (rounded up). Synthesize suits into a single complication. Do not draw for every 1 – it slows play.

Transitioning Between Tiers

From → To	Change in Mindset
Tier I → II	Stop hoarding Boons. You'll get fewer Misses. Spend Boons on Position upgrades before rolls.
Tier II → III	Success is nearly guaranteed. Accept that every roll will generate SB. Plan for complications, n
Tier III → IV	Your personal dice are maxed. Invest in followers and assets – they're now your primary leverag
Tier IV → V	You are a faction, not a person. Solve problems with assets and Debt Timers, not dice.

Closing Note

These heuristics are grounded in the game's probability math and resource economy. They are not prescriptive rules but strategic observations. The best Fate's Edge players internalize these patterns and then break them for the sake of story. When reviewing the system, assess how well it enables this kind of informed, narrative-driven decision-making.

Appendices

A Mathematical Tables

Table 1: Success Probability for DV 2–6 (Pools 1–12)

Dice	DV 2	DV 3	DV 4	DV 5	DV 6
1	0.50	0.00	0.00	0.00	0.00
2	0.75	0.25	0.00	0.00	0.00
3	0.875	0.50	0.125	0.00	0.00
4	0.9375	0.6875	0.3125	0.0625	0.00
5	0.96875	0.8125	0.5	0.1875	0.03125
6	0.984375	0.890625	0.65625	0.34375	0.109375
7	0.9921875	0.9375	0.7734375	0.5	0.2265625
8	0.99609375	0.96484375	0.85546875	0.63671875	0.36328125
9	0.998046875	0.98046875	0.91015625	0.74609375	0.5
10	0.9990234375	0.9892578125	0.9453125	0.828125	0.623046875
11	0.99951171875	0.994140625	0.9677734375	0.88671875	0.7255859375
12	0.999755859375	0.99658203125	0.9814453125	0.92724609375	0.80615234375

Table 2: Expected Story Beats (SB) per Roll by Dice Pool

Dice	Expected SB
1	0.1
2	0.2
3	0.3
4	0.4
5	0.5
6	0.6
7	0.7
8	0.8
9	0.9
10	1.0
11	1.1
12	1.2

B Glossary of Design Terminology

Narrative partnership Shared storytelling authority where players and GM co-create consequences.

Constraint lattice Rules as generative boundaries – they constrain to enable creativity, not limit it.

Table 3: Dominant vs. Controlled vs. Desperate (Success $\geq$3, 6 dice)

Position	Success Probability
Controlled (no re-roll)	89.1%
Dominant (re-roll one failure)	97.5%
Desperate (re-roll one success)	71.9%

Structural advantage Pre-scene buffs or assets that trigger Over-Stack (e.g., two active spells, an unused Follower Initiative).

Roller-coaster effect Harm clearing Fatigue – the system's anti-death spiral mechanic.

Anti-death spiral A design where taking damage resets or improves other resources instead of worsening everything.

Partial Outcome where 0 ¡ successes ¡ DV – progress with a cost, gain 1 Boon.

Miss Outcome with 0 successes – no progress, gain 2 Boons, GM escalates.

Fiction-first Mechanics are triggered by narrative description, not the other way around.

C Errata and Known Issues (Living Document)

- **Cantor Corruption reset (Player's Guide vs SRD):** The Player's Guide originally said ”set current Corruption segments to your Tier”. The SRD correctly says ”reset to zero”. Align to SRD.
- **Over-Stack optional:** Some GMs forget to apply it. Recommend adding a reminder in the GM section.
- **Deck of Consequences optional:** Under-used in playtests. Suggest drawing only when spending 2+ SB at once to keep pacing.
- **Boon Finesse (Summoner):** At epic tiers Boons are scarce, making spirit maintenance harder. This is intentional; no fix needed.

THE STRUCTURE OF NARRATIVE

[illegible]

The [illegible] boundary.

The Hollow [illegible] pressure.

Witness [illegible] obligation.

Ikasha → The unwritten. The potential.

The wo[illegible] engine.

Inaea → The trust. The bond.

They cho[illegible] their genre.

Isoka → The transformation. The character.

They [illegible] obligations.

Players feel these layers. They never name them.

They never know why. They just know it matters.